

Individual Research Report

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Topic: Digital World

Research Question: Does using social media have a negative impact on our ability to focus on tasks?

Many people, including myself, experience an inability to focus on tasks, and feel that it is due to social media. This claim is backed up by research: a study at the Technical University of Denmark studied several modes of media attention for different periods of time, and concluded that the global attention span is diminishing and getting exhausted as a result of the overwhelming volume of information presented to the public through the media. (EurekAlert, 2019). I wanted to explore some causes due to which social media has a negative impact on our ability to focus, namely depression and media multitasking, the consequences that these causes have, along with their global and national perspectives, and provide courses of action that we can take both individually and collectively to curb them.

Why is it important to be able to focus on tasks? Some of the benefits that we reap from being able to focus are that we improve our productivity, enabling us to complete our work in less time, thus allowing us to spend our time in other activities. We also significantly reduce errors when we are focused. If our individual ability to focus is lost, then our collective decisions such as political, business, community and environmental decisions also become error-prone. If we are focused, our quality of work is improved, our creativity is enhanced, and we are able to absorb and retain more information. When our ability to focus is lost, all of these are severely affected.

Scientists who claim that using social media have a negative impact on our ability to focus give multiple reasons for their claims. One reason is because of stress or depression. In a 2018 University of Pennsylvania study, researchers examined 143 undergraduates divided into two sets. The first group was instructed to limit Facebook, Instagram, and Snapchat to ten minutes per platform daily, while the second was asked to maintain their usual social media usage. The study lasted for three weeks. The group with limited social media usage demonstrated significant reductions in depression during this period compared to the group that continued using social media regularly. (McLean Hospital, 2023). From this, we can understand that using social media causes depression and stress in young people. Another study displayed that individuals using seven or more social media platforms are three times more likely to experience anxiety when compared to those who use two or fewer platforms. (Chester County Hospital, 2020). A study of library professionals in India showed that using social media caused stress in 73% of them. 37% were unable to concentrate on their studies due to social media usage (Akhtar Hussain, 2018). This shows that depression leading to loss of focus is also a major problem in India as well as the rest of the world.

This could be due to many factors on social media, including but not limited to envy of other users, feelings of inadequacy about one's own life and appearance, cyberbullying, and loneliness. Also contributing to stress is negative information shown online, which often outweighs positive information. This can be explained by research that shows that negativity generates more attention from people, even if they don't enjoy it. In a study analysing news stories, it was found that individuals globally exhibit stronger psychophysiological reactions to negative news in contrast to positive news. (Beth Elwood, 2020). Stress is closely linked to our ability to focus because, when under stress and depression, as opposed to being present with what is going on in the moment, we are instead focused on cues for potential dangers or threats: whatever is driving our anxiety. This is called hypervigilance.

To avoid stress on social media which leads to loss of attention, people can take on some individual behavioural strategies such as trying to also make time for real-world interactions along with ones on social media to reduce chances of loneliness and depression. Limits should also be set to social media use to avoid mental health issues. This might be challenging in terms of determining and following through with appropriate limits, so it helps to have an accountability partner who helps to ensure that the limits are kept. Another action people can take is to reduce the reading of negative stories online and read about more positive stories. It might be argued that this solution can create a skewed perception of reality in people, where people have limited understanding of the complexities and challenges that exist in the real world, so a substitute for this solution could be to, while reading negative stories, concentrate more on formulating possible solutions for these stories, and also perhaps implementing the solutions. Another

solution for people would be to avoid arguing with others online and going on social media apps/sites which have negative influences.

Some collective courses of action we can take as communities are to advocate for changes to social media platforms that can assist in reducing the adverse effects of social media on mental health, such as implementing algorithms that display more positive content and limit exposure to negative content, placing controls to avoid cyberbullying, and introducing features that concentrate on benefitting users rather than increasing their usage of the platform. These changes, if implemented, can have significant positive effects -why- to our mental health and in turn, ability to focus. They could perhaps also be advocated for through social media itself to raise awareness and increase the impact.

Also, our brain can only produce one or two thoughts in our conscious mind at once. However, social media is built on firing multiple different types of information at us constantly, and many people think nothing of checking their phones while performing other tasks. This is referred to as media multitasking (Natasha Matthews et al., 2022). However, “(multitasking) ruins productivity, causes mistakes, and impedes creative thought. As humans, we have a very limited capacity for simultaneous thought -- we can only hold a little bit of information in the mind at any single moment. You don’t actually multitask, you task-switch. This wastes time, makes you error-prone and decreases your ability to be creative.” (Earl Miller, 2017) The following study compared heavy media multitaskers to light media multitaskers and found that heavy media multitaskers were slower at identifying changes in patterns in experiments, and falsely recalled objects previously shown to them more often than light media multitaskers (John Wihbey, 2013). This shows that multitasking doesn’t just reduce the quality of all the tasks we are working on, it also has a long-term effect on our ability to focus on tasks.

One of the effects of media multitasking is so dangerous it’s life threatening, and, according to NHTSA, 2022, claimed the lives of 3,142 people in the U.S. in 2020, and 3,522 in 2021. It is distracted driving. There are other reasons for being distracted while driving, such as talking with co-passengers, eating, or drinking, but a majority of these accidents occur because of talking/texting on or handling the phone. This is shown by the following study: The percent of fatal crashes involving distraction due to mobile phone usage in 2021 was 11.7%. These figures explain to us how dangerous loss of focus and multitasking can be (National Safety Council, 2022).

What about Indian drivers? India is the top contributor to global road crash mortality figures. In the last decade alone, 1.3 million people in India were killed due to road accidents and an additional 5.3 million were permanently disabled. 28% of drivers in India, and a colossal 65% of drivers in one of its most populated cities, Bengaluru, make calls while driving. (Save Life Foundation, 2017)

Once again, some personal approaches we can take to reduce multitasking online: We must block all notifications that we receive except for ones that are important and urgent, because even if we don’t open up the notification and respond to it, it pulls us out of our focus on our tasks. However, even if we receive important notifications, there is a possibility of missing out on some critical information, so we must still keep ourselves up-to-date on our communication at least once a day, perhaps after our work is complete. We must also assign a time once a day and read news articles/social media posts up to a certain limit, say, 3 articles and 10 posts, and steer clear of them for the rest of the day to avoid information overload. Another method is to engage in slow, mindful practices while concentrating on one thing to improve our ability to focus. Some common cultural Indian practices are slow activities that increase our ability to focus, such as meditation, ayurveda and yoga. However, some of these are intertwined with religious/philosophical beliefs, so it is important to find activities that align with one’s personal beliefs. Also, work on tasks in chunks of time

because as time spent on most tasks increases, our attention wanes and we get more prone to getting distracted. Note that this is not necessarily the case with all tasks, and some tasks, if interrupted in between, affect productivity and workflow. Therefore, it is important to determine which tasks are better done in chunks of time and which are better done at one go.

Before I began my research on this report, I strongly believed that using social media affects our ability to focus on tasks, but always thought the causes to be reasons such as distraction or fear of missing out. While doing my research, I came to think about my own focus and how it now actually reflected some of the things that I was researching about, and I realised how the deterioration of your focus is not something that you even realise is happening, but it is taking hold of you nonetheless. I decided to implement the courses of action from both issues to improve my ability to focus and also raise awareness about it among the people around me because though this topic of the destructive effects of social media is common, many people, as I used to before my research, do not seriously consider the effects that it has. For instance, I didn't know that depression was a reason for inability to focus, and never considered the dangerous effects that it has on our lives in the long-term, such as actually reducing our attention span and ability to focus, and even taking the lives of some people in the case of distracted driving. In future, I will encourage the people I know to avoid talking on the phone or scrolling while driving.

Most of the sources I have referred to have been published in the last 5 years (i.e. from 2018-2023), but some of them have been published a couple of years earlier, which might put their information at the risk of being outdated. All of my sources have been published online for educational purposes, by organisations, universities such as the Massachusetts Institute of Technology, or are government websites (extension .gov). This ensures that there is no potential bias. However, authors have not been mentioned in many of them, so they might have been written by people with little to no experience with the topic, which can make some of its information false.

In conclusion, the claim that social media negatively affects our ability to focus has been proven to be true, and has multiple reasons, two of them being depression and multitasking. We can apply multiple strategies to reduce the effects of social media on our focus, such as limiting our social media use, engaging in mindful practices and real-world interactions, consuming more positive content than negative, task chunking, and collectively advocating for improvements to social media platforms that can help minimise the harmful influences of social media on mental health and well-being. These strategies may seem minor, but if applied, they will be instrumental in improving our lives on a personal as well as a global level.

[1991 words]

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